On the appointed day, at the appointed hour
Replete and multitudinous, the army set out for Kabul

When the horde was set in motion from that land
The earth shook to its very foundations

Accompanying the Shah, by way of Sindh
Were one hundred and fifty thousand hand-picked soldiers

By another route, Timur, Wade and *Daktar* [Doctor] Lord
Were on their way with five thousand other soldiers

Two raging rivers from two different directions
Made their way to Kabul from Ludhiana

The ruler of every region and province
Was as obedient as wax to the Shah's seal ring

The stamping horses reached the mountains of Sindh
And entered the deserts of Hind

Sweating and over-loaded camels
Flooded through the mountainous road

The cannon and the elephants marched together
Like a mountain moving from its place with the force of the River Nile.[25]

Once a British camp and bridgehead had been established at Shikarpur, in the absence of further camels to move the supplies of war, ammunition and food stores began to be sent down the Indus by fleets of hastily requisitioned barges – 'flat bottomed, very shallow and broader at the stern than at the bow, which rise to a peak some fourteen feet out of the water', remembered a young infantryman, Thomas Seaton, who was given charge of one supply convoy. 'In this queer conveyance a straw hut of two rooms had been built, and as all the boats in the fleet – about fifty – were exactly like mine, they looked like a floating village.'[26] By the end of February the entire arsenal had arrived at Shikarpur; and by the end of the month the last of the Bombay troops had marched in too.

All that was now needed was a bridge. The river was more than a thousand yards wide 'with a torrent like a mill stream', and initially the engineers had only eight boats 'and nothing near us but a small village . . .